



'THE GREATEST BARRIER IS OFTEN CONVICTION'

Falguni Nayar

► **WHEN NAYAR STEPPED** away from Kotak Mahindra Capital in 2012 after nearly two decades in investment banking, the decision was deliberate, though what came next was not fully mapped out.

"The 19 years I spent at Kotak Mahindra Group were deeply formative," Nayar says. "It was a front-row seat to how businesses are built, scaled, and taken to the world."

Nayar said that over time, she developed a deep appreciation for entrepreneurs, their ability to build from nothing, navigate uncertainty, and stay committed to a long-term vision despite short-term challenges.

By the time she reached her 50s, Nayar found herself confronting a deeply personal question. "If not now, then when?" she recalls asking herself. "I was 50, and I did not want the idea of timing or age to define the next phase of my life." As she explored consumer behaviour and gaps across industries, the beauty category stood out as large, fast-growing, yet underserved.

"At the same time, digital adoption and e-commerce were beginning to reshape consumption in India," she says, "an insight that eventually became the foundation for Nykaa."

For Nayar, however, building Nykaa required far more than applying lessons from corporate leadership. It demanded continuous learning. "I was new to technology and retail, both of which I learned from scratch," she says. "The first few years were tough. We faced system crashes and execution delays, but treated them as learning." Her vision to build a brand that consumers trusted led her to create Nykaa. "Everything we promised, we delivered."

Nayar believes the larger question is not whether



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India Inc is ready for such transitions, but whether individuals are willing to leap. She says that the greatest barrier is often conviction and the willingness to take the first step despite uncertainty.

"The years you have spent understanding businesses, managing people, and navigating complexity are your edge," she says.

India is still creating new categories, new consumption behaviours, and new institutions. For those who have spent decades building knowledge and judgment, there has never been a better time to put that to use.

Even today, Nayar says curiosity remains one of the strongest driving forces in her life. She continues to read widely across consumer behaviour, technology shifts, and evolving market trends, while travel remains an important source of learning and perspective.